FT FollowThrough

The House Cleaning Playbook

What to say from the first call to the five-star review. Copy the lines, put them in your own words, and keep this on your phone.

1. The first call or message

Sound calm, understand the job, and book a next step. Ask:

- How many bedrooms and bathrooms, and about how many square feet?
- A one-time deep clean, a move-out clean, or regular visits? Weekly, every other week or monthly?
- When was the last full clean? Any pets?
- Anything you'd like us to focus on, or to stay out of?

> "Thanks for calling [Business], this is [Name]. Tell me about your home and I'll see how we can help."

> "I can send a price today and do a quick walkthrough Tuesday at 11 or Thursday at 4. Which works better?"

2. Presenting the quote

- Send your room-by-room checklist with every quote, so "clean" means the same thing to both of you.
- Price the first visit as a deep clean, then the regular visit price.
- Show weekly and every-other-week prices side by side.
- Put your cancellation, lockout and payment policy in writing.

> "Here's the checklist, here's the first deep clean and here's the price for regular visits. I have [day] open. Which would you like to start with?"

3. The 7 objections cleaners hear and what to say

Acknowledge it, ask a question, answer honestly, suggest a next step.

1. "The last cleaner I called was cheaper."
"That's fair, I'd compare too. What did their price include? Ask whether it covers baseboards, inside the microwave, insurance and a bond. I'll send my room-by-room checklist so you can compare line by line."

2. "I want to get a few more quotes first."
"That makes sense. What matters most to you in a cleaner? When you compare, ask who actually shows up, whether it's the same person every visit, and what happens if something breaks. I'll text you Thursday to answer any questions."

3. "Can you do every other week for the weekly price?"
"I see why you'd ask. How long has it been since the last full clean? Every-other-week visits take longer because more builds up, so they cost more per visit. I'll send both prices side by side so you can pick what fits your budget."

4. "I can just do it myself."
"You definitely can. How many hours does it take you each week? Many clients keep the daily tidying and hand me the bathrooms, floors and kitchen. Want to try one clean and see what the time back is worth to you?"

5. “Maybe after the holidays.”
“Understood, it’s a busy time. Are you hosting anyone this year? Holiday weeks book up early, and the longer a home goes, the longer and pricier the first clean gets. I can do one deep clean now and start regular visits in January.”

6. “I’m not comfortable with a stranger in my house.”
“That’s completely fair. What would help you feel comfortable? I’m insured and bonded, I can share references, and the same person comes every visit. You don’t have to be home, but I’m happy to do a walkthrough with you before the first clean.”

7. “Why do you need my card on file?”
“Fair question. Would another way to pay suit you better? The card is charged only after each clean, with a receipt by text, and it covers the late-cancellation fee in my policy. I’ll send the policy so you can read it first.”

4. Follow up: day 2, day 5, day 12

Most quotes go quiet, not “no”. Keep each message short and useful.

> **Day 2:** “Hi [Name], it’s [Your name] from [Business]. Did the quote and checklist come through okay? Happy to answer any questions.”

> **Day 5:** “Hi [Name], I have a [day] opening for your first clean. Want me to hold it for you until Friday?”

> **Day 12:** “Hi [Name], I’ll close out your quote on Friday. If you’d like just one deep clean to try us out, reply and I’ll fit you in.”

After every one-time deep clean, offer a regular slot the same day. Most recurring clients start that way.

5. Ask for the review and the referral

Ask after the first regular visit, once they’ve come home to a clean house, and text a direct link to your Google review page.

> “Thanks again, [Name]. If you’re happy with the clean, would you leave a quick Google review? I’ll text you the link. And if a friend is looking for a cleaner, I’d be glad to help.”

Realtors and property managers need move-out cleans every month. One good move-out clean can bring a steady stream.

Three rules that keep you out of trouble

- Carry insurance and a bond. One broken heirloom or theft claim can cost more than years of premiums.
- Pay helpers as employees if they work like employees, and pay them for drive time between homes.
- Charge on the day of the clean, and put your cancellation and lockout fees in writing.

General education, not legal, tax or insurance advice. Rules and prices vary by state, so check yours.